White Flight and Residential Segregation in Mobile County, AL: Aligning Historical Indicators and U.S. Census Bureau Data to Model Dissimilaritiy

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Abstract

This study analyzes demographic shifts in Mobile County, AL from 1960 to the present to assess the persistence of residential segregation. By utilizing decennial census data and spatial analysis, the research examines how structural and historical forces continue to drive spatial inequality in the post–civil rights era.

Overview

White Flight and Segregation. White flight occurs when white individuals abandon integrated spaces to avoid growing minority populations and stall racial progress. This migration is driven by the desire to protect "whiteness as property," where distancing themselves from other races preserves their social and economic capital (Crowder & South, 2008). In Mobile, desegregation efforts were only made when they protected the elite's economic interests and established new, spatial forms of white exclusivity (Bell, 1980).

Segregation Facilitators.

- *Whiteness as property*: Whiteness is not just viewed as a racial identity, but as a legal and social asset that operates at a systems level. It posits that European ancestry carries a distinct set of inherent privileges, sociopolitical status, and expectations of entitlement that function as a protected form of property (Donner, 2021).
- *Interest Convergence*: Racial equality is achieved when the interests of Black people align with the self-interests of a white majority (Bell, 1980).

Literature Review

- Between 1970-1980, Mobile County saw a significant decline in public school enrollment (approx. 11,500 students), directly correlating with a rise in private school attendance and suburban migration (Pride, 2022). This period highlights a distinct pattern of "white flight" from urban centers to suburban districts.
- Research indicates that white residents often undervalue racially integrated areas due to an "aversion to living near black neighbors" and inflated perceptions of crime (Crowder & South, 2008). These subjective assessments frequently override objective neighborhood quality, driving residential turnover.

Historical Evolution of Racial Categories

Before 1950, racial classification was determined by census enumerators using externally imposed categories rooted in "color," ancestry, and racial hierarchy (e.g., White, Black, Mulatto). These systems reflected the "one-drop rule" and did not rely on self-identification.

Decade	Enumeration Method	Key Changes Relevant to Study
1950	Enumerator	Race assigned by enumerators; "Negro" used; no "Black" category
1960	Mixed (Enumerator + Self-ID)	Transitional system; partial shift toward self-identification
1970	Self-identification	First full use of self-identification; "Black" reintroduced
1980	Self-identification	Expanded racial categories; terminology reordered ("Black or Negro")
1990	Self-identification	"Race" replaces "Color or Race"; Asian/Pacific categories grouped
2000	Self-identification (multi-race allowed)	Respondents can select multiple races; "African American" added
2010	Self-identification (multi-race)	Same categories as 2000; clarified race vs. Hispanic origin

Because racial classification methods and terminology changed over time—particularly the shift from enumerator-assigned race to self-identification—this study standardizes categories into "Black" and "White" to enable longitudinal comparison across census decades.

Research Questions

How have Black and white racial demographics across tracts in Mobile County evolved from 1980-2020?

Model

$$D = \frac{1}{2}\sum_{i=1}^{n}\left|\frac{b_i}{B} - \frac{w_i}{W}\right|$$

where b_i is the population of Black households in neighborhood i, B is the total Black population in the geographical area, w_i is the population of non-Black households in neighborhood i, W is the total non-Black population in the geographical area.

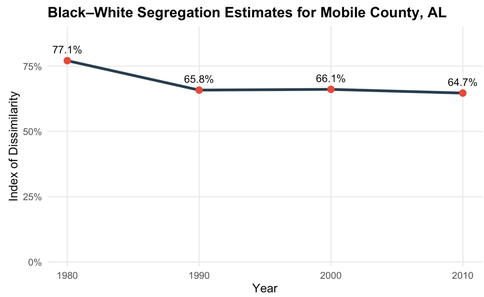
Hypothesis

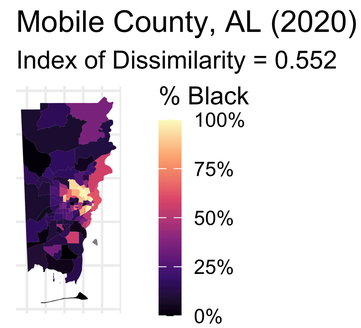
Levels of residential segregation will remain persistently high, reflecting the continued influence of structural factors such as white flight and path-dependent patterns of residential sorting.

Methods and Data

This study uses historical census data from the U.S. Census Bureau to examine changes in Black and white residential distribution across census tracts in Mobile County from 1960 to 2010. Data are analyzed using spatiotemporal demographic mapping, involving longitudinal comparison of tract-level racial composition and the calculation of segregation indices across decennial census years. Our interpretation of observed trends is informed by a Critical Race Theory framework, particularly the concepts of interest convergence and whiteness as property, to contextualize segregation patterns over time.

Findings





Discussion

Conclusion

Acknowledgements

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References